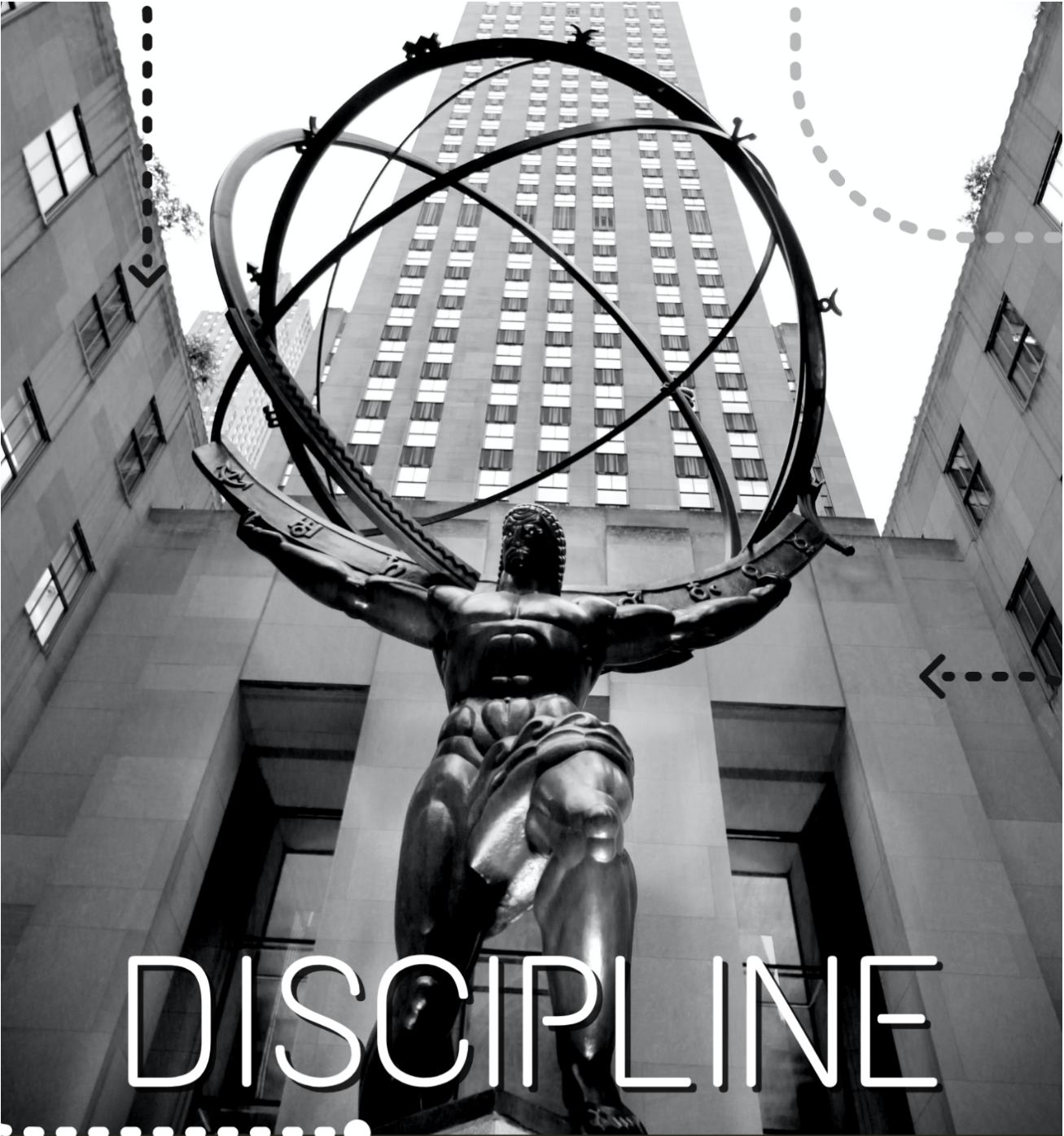




DISCIPLINE

& FINDING YOUR
EDGE

by

KIM ANN CURTIN

THE WALL STREET COACH

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Introduction

John Lennon famously said, “Life is what happens to you while you’re busy making other plans.”

Most of us can relate to this paradox in one way or another.

For me, the path to coaching traders actually began with working in the high-pressure world of Wall Street. I worked there for almost a decade before I started as a coach.

Interestingly, part of why I was drawn to coaching in the first place was that I craved more equanimity and peace in my own life. I craved a contrast to the high-stress world in which I resided.

The pressure is intense on Wall Street even on a good day. But during the pinnacle of the years when I worked there — during the financial crisis of 2007-2008 — it was on a whole different level.

During that time, I hired a coach for myself. It was game-changing.

I began to think about how the lessons that were so paradigm-shifting for me could be applied to the high-pressure world of Wall Street. If ever there was a population that could really use some emotional tools...

I have always had an affection for traders — they are entrepreneurial, and I am too. I know it takes a lot of guts to be doing something like this for yourself and charting your own course.

While I continue to learn more about trading and have executed trades both in real life and as a paper trader, I do not identify as a trader myself.

It’s not necessarily my aspiration to become a great trader, because it is not my passion.

My passion is coaching. That’s where I prefer to apply my knowledge. But given my knowledge of the high-pressure world of trading, I love being able to assist this population through my work.

My time on Wall Street gave me an education on what roadblocks traders face.

In this series of books, I’ve addressed some of the most common and prevalent roadblocks that traders face.

In this final installment, I'm focusing on one of the biggest roadblocks that can have the longest-lasting and farthest-reaching effects for traders — struggles with discipline and a lack of proven edge.

These are some of the most common struggles I see traders facing. But they're also some of the trickiest ones, because like the other struggles I've addressed in this series, they're really just symptoms of issues that lie much deeper inside.

Let's take a journey to see what lies beneath.

In this book, you'll learn what really plays into a struggle with discipline and a lack of an edge — and proactive steps traders can take to address them.

Armed with greater knowledge about yourself and your tendencies, you'll be able to move forward more confidently in trading — and maybe even in life!

Chapter 1: What's Your Edge?: Why Traders Struggle With Discipline + a Lack of Proven Edge

Struggles with discipline and a lack of proven edge are two of the most common ongoing issues I hear about from traders. Interestingly, these struggles are not limited to new traders. Rather, both new traders and seasoned traders with decades-long careers report these roadblocks.

Discipline: A Trader's Constant Companion

You probably know what discipline is — an action or series of actions that are meant to maintain regulation within a particular system.

Discipline is vital for traders. On an initial level, discipline is necessary to help you establish a set of rules to trade by. But your work isn't done once you've established those rules. Discipline is required for the rest of your trading career to help you stick to that set of rules.

There's never a point at which discipline isn't required for traders.

You'd think that given this fact traders would get really, really good about discipline — that it would become second nature.

But that's not the case. Even longtime, established traders struggle with maintaining discipline.

Here's an example of how a lack of discipline can work against traders...

Say that you're a day trader who focuses on tech stocks. Perhaps you have certain criteria you always like to look for — unusually high volume, percentage spikes over a certain amount, a strong news catalyst, etc.

Once you've established these criteria, finding trades should be easy. Right?

Not quite. Because emotions can start to kick in and make you begin to rationalize unhealthy actions.

For instance, if it's a slow trading day and you're bored and you just want some action, you might start talking yourself into the idea that even though this stock isn't that liquid and there's no catalyst, maybe it's still worth trading...

It's a pretty common phenomenon, but there's also a clue in this type of behavior. When it comes down to it, the real problem isn't a lack of discipline but the tricky emotions that get in the way and blind your vision...

Lack of Proven Edge

Like I said, you're probably familiar with the concept of discipline. But what about the lack of a proven edge?

Think of photographers lining up to take photos at a red carpet event. They're all seeing the same stars walk down the carpet. But some photographers will get better photos than others. Maybe they're at a better angle. Maybe they think of a clever way to nail the shot. Maybe they just get lucky.

It's like that with trading. Your "edge" is kind of like your angle. How can you approach the trade just a little differently from everyone else to position yourself at an advantage?

Before I go any further, it's important to note that an edge in trading usually isn't immediately evident. It often takes time to figure out and develop your edge.

Because of this fact, traders shouldn't obsess about finding an edge right away. They should focus on learning the mechanics of the market and learning the rules of trading.

As traders begin to refine their process and develop a trading style, they'll begin to notice their strengths and weaknesses and what strategies they gravitate toward. All of this can help inform identifying an edge in trading.

It's a process. It's also not just about having any old edge. It's about having an edge that works for you and reflects you, how you show up in the world, your temperament, and your comfort level.

Finding Your Edge: Words For New Traders

To new traders, my best advice about finding an edge is this:

It takes time. It doesn't happen overnight.

Trading is complex. It's one of the most competitive games in the world. You're up against the smartest people — not only in the room, but in the world.

That means that for you to find that edge that speaks to you — that makes you say yes, this is my sweet spot — you've got to give yourself room to find it.

It also means getting in touch with who you are and what your needs are.

I often speak to traders about what needs they might be using trading to fulfill — good or bad. For instance, if you're using trading to fulfill your need for adventure, it could be a good thing — or it could become a problem if you're taking unnecessary risks just to catch a thrill.

When you get more in-tune with what your needs are, it can affect how you interact with everything around you.

It can also clue you in on what's really behind struggling with discipline or a lack of proven edge.

What many traders perceive as a lack of discipline or a lack of proven edge is actually much more layered and complicated than that. Often, it's built on a whole lifetime of your tendencies and experiences.

Chapter 2: Know Your Tendencies: How Self-Awareness is the Path to Finding Your Edge

I'm a huge advocate of self-work and self-awareness. I believe that the more in-tune you are with yourself, the more in tune you become with yourself and your way of interacting with the world, the more successful you will be with recognizing what informs your discipline (or lack thereof) and finding your edge.

In general, it puts you more in contact with what works for you as a trader.

So how can you begin to cultivate self-awareness that can help you develop more connection with yourself? For many traders, it can be a powerful exercise to start by assessing their tendencies.

What's Your Tendency?

Everyone has their tendencies. We all have our own unique preferences and characteristics.

You probably already know that.

But what few traders consider is that these tendencies can affect their trading.

To that end, understanding what your tendencies are can help you make better decisions for what will work for you as a trader.

So ... What's your tendency?

In her book "The Four Tendencies," Gretchen Rubin posits that there are four key personality types.

She suggests that by simply getting curious about what your main tendency is, it can transform how you conduct yourself in work, at home, and in life. That carries over to trading!

Her book began with a simple question: "How do I respond to expectations?"

It led to an in-depth exploration that resulted in the observation that based on this simple question, most people fall into one of four tendencies: Upholders, Questioners, Obligers, and Rebels.

This tendency has the power to touch every aspect of your behavior — by using the framework in her book, it's possible to gain a better understanding of what drives our decisions, stress, and how we engage with the world.

I highly suggest the book, but for the purposes of this exercise, there's also a free quiz on GretchenRubin.com where you can quickly identify your primary tendency. It's far from the only assessment out there, but it's quick, easy, and free — so why not give it a try?

Here are the four tendencies according to Rubin:

The Upholder

These are people who want to know what should be done and what needs to be done. Armed with this information, they are going to make it happen — no matter what.

The Upholder is usually great at following directions. That's a good thing! But it comes at the risk of the person in question swinging too far and becoming rigid.

The Questioner

The Questioner is driven by two primary things: justification and purpose.

They want to know the “why” behind what they're doing — all the time. They're very inquisitive, and feel as if they need this side of them to be satisfied to justify pursuing anything.

The Obliger

The Obliger is often in service of something or someone else. They need accountability for things that are outside of themselves.

Actually, I'm an obliger! For me, that shows as an ability to show up for others in need or who may depend on me ... But I don't always give myself the same courtesy.

The Rebel

Freedom is the name of the game for the rebel. They need the freedom and space to do things their own way.

But sometimes it comes at a cost. They may be resistant to their own needs and those around them in the service of being able to conduct themselves in a way that is different.

Understanding Tendencies

Do you find yourself identifying with more than one of these tendencies? Not surprising. Every single one of us will have a little bit of all of these tendencies.

However, taking the quiz can be a good starting point to see what your predisposition might be and what you lean toward. It allows you to better position yourself for success.

By figuring out what your tendency is, you can take steps to go about making sure you are honoring yourself.

Also worth noting: identifying your primary tendency is not intended as a first step toward abolishing it. The goal is not necessarily to change your tendency. It's about strategizing in a way that is inclusive.

For the purposes of this book, the idea is not to change yourself. It's to meet yourself where you are.

By simply identifying your tendency, you may be better able to make lifestyle changes that do create a shift in how you conduct yourself — either as a human being, a trader, or both.

Once again, it comes back to a dominant theme throughout this series: curiosity and neutrality...

Curiosity & Neutrality: Your Hidden Allies

The more curious you are, the better able you will be to operate from a place of non-judgment. This can allow you to be in a mode of information gathering rather than scrutinizing yourself.

This mindset can help you preempt bad behavior and negative ways of showing up in trading and beyond. It can affect how you show up with your family — and everything and everyone else in your life.

Let's illustrate with an example.

Say that you know that your tendency is the Upholder. You're great at following the rules — but you also need a set of rules to be able to follow.

If you're that type, it's going to be important to make sure you have the necessary information or a set of rules to follow.

You need that “map.”

If you're given ambiguity about what is expected of you, you're going to feel really uncomfortable. You might not be in the best place to make important decisions. If you know this, you may be able to take better steps to ensure that you have a set of rules in place before you take on a trade.

This curiosity extends to the other side of your tendency — how it may affect others.

It's important to be aware of how others might perceive your type.

For example, as a Questioner, you may recognize that it's inherent to your nature to have a lot of questions.

However, others might be taken aback and perceive your constant questioning as interrogation. So you've got to have some empathy for those around you.

Awareness of your own tendencies as well as those around you can have positive effects in your life.

For instance, imagine that you're married to a Questioner. If you try to hit up your partner to pick up bread, you can expect a barrage of questions: what kind? Where? Why?

In knowing your partner's tendencies, you might be more proactive and say “Please pick up sourdough bread because my mother is coming this afternoon and that's her favorite kind so I want to have it on hand.” You might still get some questions, but at least by being proactive you might avoid the full-on barrage.

On the other hand, if you are that Questioner, consider how exasperating your tendency could be to others. In terms of your trading, you may want to consider this when choosing a mentor or when pursuing further education.

In time, you may notice that you get good at noticing what tendencies others have. This can allow you to listen to and interact with them through the lens of their type.

Practice it. Observe people. It can help you identify your own tendencies better and help you make sense of your place in the world, both in relation to yourself and those around you.

From a trading perspective, this can also help remind you that the people on the other side of your trade will have one of these tendencies. How could that give you an edge?

For instance, if you wanted to buy a stock and consider the idea that the current sellers might be Questioners or Uplolders, how might that information change your strategy?

Think back to the sourdough bread example. Could there be a way that considering the tendencies of others could help you seek out what you want with less friction? How could that help you in trading?

Your Own Tendencies in Trades

Let's get down to business: how are your tendencies affecting your trading?

Once again, curiosity is key. Try to view your own behavior through a lens of curiosity and with understanding of your tendency.

For example, if you're feeling challenged, what is happening for you? What could be happening to trigger it? Are you reacting from a place of one of these tendencies?

One common problem traders face is overtrading. This could be tied to a Rebel tendency. It's possible that the overtrading is happening to that rebellious inner reaction, "No! I'm not going to listen to what my mentor says. I'm not going to listen to what everyone else is doing. I'm going to take my own route."

Sometimes, this might be fine. But if your tendency is costing you at every turn and the losses are mounting, it might be time to look at your behaviors and get curious about what's driving them.

It doesn't have to be a huge deal. It's more a mindset shift: "How do I take this and make it work for me instead of letting it be a driver against me?"

Chapter 3: Who's Driving the Bus? How Inner Gremlins Keep Traders From Finding an Edge

Imagine a bus that's driving out of control. There's a gremlin in the driver's seat, and you can bet they're not a responsible driver who's adjusted the mirrors and uses proper turn signals.

This is what it's like when your inner gremlin is driving you.

If you keep letting that inner gremlin take the wheel inside of you, you've stopped being an observer of places that you're driving to that keep giving you the same results.

Is that the case? If so, for the moment, don't worry about the results you're getting in your trading. Instead, be more curious about the path you're taking that is getting you to that result.

It's so easy to look with dismay at a sandcastle that is crumbled to the ground. It took so much time to make — just look at that massacre.

But perhaps the more important questions involve the process. What kind of sand did you use — was it too wet or dry? What forms were you using to make those turrets?

Look at the pieces that go into what you're building versus being sentimental about the loss itself. Try to be an outside observer witnessing what's going on.

Track Your Emotional Data

Most traders track their trades (and if you don't, you should!).

But are you actually tracking everything that could help you?

Most traders will log details like entry and exits, time of day, the ticker symbol, and other basics.

What they don't do is track their emotional state of mind during the trade.

So for instance, as you track that you traded X on this day, with a position size of x shares, at so-and-so-times, also note anything that could have played into your state of mind.

For example...

- *I had a fight with my best friend that happened 2 days ago and I'm still annoyed.*
- *It's been 17 days of rain and I've had enough.*
- *My wife just asked for a divorce.*
- *My kids are mad at me.*
- *I'm stressed about bills.*

We all deal with pressure and various forces that are impacting us at pretty much all times. Consider these factors while you begin to unpack why you're doing what you're doing.

Questioning "Why"

When it comes to the context of questioning one's trading tendencies, I tend to shy away from the word "why."

The reason is that I don't like how it begins a process of justifying and defending.

Consider this. If I were to say to you — or even if you were to say to yourself — "Why did you do that?" it instantly creates a sense of energy like you did something wrong. It makes you feel suspicious. It makes you beat yourself up, that type of self-questioning.

Yet this is the word we use and hear all around us and internally all the time.

One of my biggest motivations as a coach is that I want to take away "why" and replace it with "what."

So instead of "Why did you do that?" the question might become "What was going on for me?" "What happened?" or "What informed that?"

This can create more curiosity and less of a defense mechanism.

That alone can be a major shift for a lot of people.

When you start wondering what happened versus why, you begin to step into a place of curiosity.

Maybe you'll begin to find answers by looking at what preceded the event or what triggered it.

But you definitely can't do that if you're contracted and defensive and made to feel ashamed.

If you frequently fall into that "why" trap, don't beat yourself up. Our culture has conditioned us to be that way! We think our worthiness is based on how we show up and whether or not we have success.

Does that sound like you? If so, I have something very important to share...

A Vital Revelation About Worthiness

Our worthiness is not predicated on anything that we do or don't do.

You do not have to earn worthiness.

It is our birthright as human beings. We are worthy.

If this sounds out of bounds to you, it's understandable. We've been taught culturally and in just about every context possible that worthiness must be earned.

Many of us are walking around life believing that we are inherently damaged goods and that the purpose of our life is to prove and crawl up and earn our worthiness.

This is one of the biggest sources of misinformation that exists — a lack of knowing our worthiness.

Consider an infant. Even if you don't have children, you've probably been around a baby at some point. One thing that's incredible about an infant is that pretty much everyone can see their preciousness.

That preciousness does not dissipate. We grow up and do things wrong, but it does not diminish our preciousness. It always resides inside of us. Of you.

Nobody would talk to an infant with an accusatory tone, saying "Why did you do that?" — yet we do that to ourselves all the time.

Let's bring it back to trading.

What if you began to address yourself and speak to yourself and look for your edge in trading through a place of neutrality, curiosity, and understanding, and seeing yourself as already worthy?

For instance, what if you approached yourself saying “Wow, you became a trader. You went into the most competitive game in the world. Good job! You’re gutsy.”

From that place, perhaps you can try shifting your mindset from “Why can’t I do this?” to “Let’s see if you can do this.”

When you bump into not being able to do it, get curious. That’s where change can truly begin.

Getting Curious About Your Edge

What if you were able to look at your lack of an edge not as a fatal failing, but as a very interesting puzzle, like a tricky crossword clue?

Every trader is different. Every edge is different.

It’s a very unique imprint, your personal edge. It requires understanding how you tick and recognizing that it may be different from the majority of other people.

This doesn’t make you less-than. However, it does make you very specific.

You have a very specific tendency — or more than one. You want to get curious about what they are.

Here’s an important distinction — what matters a lot more than why here.

Why can take you into a rabbit hole for years. But what good does it do for you right now?

Understanding the concept of why is like the booby prize. Don’t get caught up. It’s a diversion.

Understanding how you operate is what you really need.

Think about it this way. If you’re going to drive a Maserati, you’re going to handle that car a whole lot differently than you would a pickup truck.

Cars are predisposed to different types of fuel, different mechanics, different needs.

Everything and everyone operates a little differently.

Your job as a trader is to start identifying how you operate.

Start to get as curious as you can about yourself. How can you best operate the vehicle that is you?

Before I close this topic, I do want to say that “why” does have a time and a place. If you’re interested in a deeper dive, Simon Sinek addresses it in a TED talk called “How Great Leaders Inspire Action.”

Asking why isn’t always problematic. If the question elicits inquiry versus judgment that can be a good thing. The real important thing is to not fall into the diversion and to focus on what will actually work in your favor right now.

Chapter 4: Are You Questioning Yourself into Analysis Paralysis?

There are so many directions you can go in trading. There's always another potential pivot or a different strategy.

Once, I had a session with a trader who was constantly questioning and second-guessing himself. "Am I right? Do I have enough confidence?"

For him, it was due to a lack of confidence in knowing who he was. He openly admitted that he didn't feel he had the soul of a day trader. The chaos and fast pace was hard for him. He'd never been one to make decisions on the fly. When he felt unprepared and rushed, he knew he was not his best self.

Did this mean he was bound to fail as a trader? Definitely not. Did it mean he's a trader who didn't like pressure? Definitely yes.

In knowing this about himself, he actually had an opportunity. What if he found patterns and a pace that worked better with his preferences?

For instance, the slightly slower pace of swing trading might be a great fit for him — as well as the fact that it relies on more analysis and thought before the trade.

Another strategy that might work for him is automating his systems — setting up automatic stops that would get him out of trades once they enter a state of chaos that he's not comfortable with.

Or ... What if he only day-traded when the rare setup that he was comfortable with came along?

In his case, he actually had a lot more clarity on what worked and what didn't than he even realized.

The problem was that he was trying to oppose it rather than go with it. But once he began to see things differently, he opened himself up to other opportunities for trading success.

What Needs Need to Be Met?

Another thing that may help you get a better handle on your analysis paralysis is getting clear on what needs you're attempting to meet through trading.

Another client came to day trading from a unique point of view — he came from the institutional side of trading. He'd worked at hedge funds.

But as a day trader, he was constantly plagued by doubt.

Before just about every trade, he would think to himself, "Why did you do that? Why, you idiot?" Every time, he'd think it wasn't good enough, or question it.

This mentality came directly from his hedge fund days. It was very much the attitude that he was up against in that type of setting. These were the questions his higher-ups would ask of him and of each other constantly.

Is it any wonder that when he trades now, he tends to overthink it and suffer from paralysis?

This particular client self-identified as an obliher — but as a bit of a questioner, too.

He'd want to do what was right, but that led him to a line of inquiry that would make him miss the boat.

Once again, this was residual from his institutional days. In such a setting, there's so much work on the back end to be done before any and every trade. It was showing up as a lack of confidence in his current trading.

I introduced this idea: what if he took what was good from those days and applied it to his current trading?

For instance, in an institutional setting, there's a concrete method with strict rules. And he liked that.

But now, he feels that he has to go into a totally different mindset. He's scared he won't be able to replicate successes. "If I have a great trade today, how do I guarantee I can replicate it tomorrow?"
But what if he began to create a new system of rules that suited his current style of trading?

Of course, that's easier said than done. It takes time.

This client fought the baggage from his institutional days every single day.

So really, his first step was to be a lot gentler on himself.

When you're asked why like that all the time, of course you begin to become defensive!

You're like a dog that is used to being hit at certain times. They learn to dodge and shy away and get out of the way.

But by showing himself compassion and getting curious, he was able to make the first step toward enacting real change.

The Struggle is Real...

Our corporate structure is a mess of "why." It's a culture that puts second-guessing on a pedestal.

What big corporations don't realize is that it's costing them a lot — I mean that literally, in dollars. When workers are being weighed down by doubt brought on by "why," they can't possibly perform at their best.

The struggle is real in this world! It's exhausting and demoralizing.

It all comes from a scarcity mindset that dictates that nothing is enough.

That mindset is false. As a trader and as a human being, you need to deprogram yourself from that brainwashing.

It all starts with curiosity and noticing yourself.

When you start to hear these all-too-familiar voices in your head, you may be able to identify them as not your own. But even so, you might want to take a pause.

You might want to avoid trading when you know these forces are at work, messing with your head.

At the very least, notice what happens inside of you when you face these types of questions. If it helps, keep a list where you make a check mark every time you have one come up. You will likely be overwhelmed by how often it happens. It could happen hundreds of times per day!

But maybe if you do keep that list, it will tell you how badly you need to make a change and help you understand how weighed down you truly are.

It's perfectly acceptable to want to move on because you're sick of it!

Chapter 5: Moving Forward + Why Comparison is the Thief of Joy

The same client from the last chapter who came from an institutional background was also a former athlete. Like many of us, he was shaped by his personal history.

At times, he felt like there were two versions of him: the one who had been shaped by institutional trading, and the one who had been a promising athlete who came to the U.S. on a scholarship.

The part of him that came from institutional trading was driven by results. The former athlete part understood the importance of putting in the work and not being results-oriented.

His hope was to bring these two sides together so he could maximize the knowledge that he had from his prior trading but the mindset that he had from his athlete days. How's that for next-level stuff?

The next steps suggested for this client may speak to the athlete mindset, but they're actually pretty universal ideas.

Focus on the Process

My client already understood that he could benefit from a basic yet profound athletic mindset: if you do all the steps, you'll get the results. But if you're focused on results, you'll skip the steps to actually get there.

That mental baggage — being blinded by visions of results — gets in the way, big time. It takes on a quality of sabotage.

Focusing solely on results has consequences. Athletes know that. That's why they train.

You probably know this, too.

You know that to be a trader, you've got to focus on the process and learning the ropes.

But that inner gremlin's voice can be so strong. It's very specifically conditioned to brow-beat you. After a while, it can become your default setting.

Interested in learning more? There's a fantastic book that actually connects athletic training to my work — coaching.

It's called "The Inner Game of Tennis: The Classic Guide to the Mental Side of Peak Performance." It was written by W. Timothy Gallwey, the grandfather of the coaching industry.

He initially began to use this technique with tennis players, but he had an aha moment when he realized that these lessons were applicable way beyond just the sports world. He realized he could take these applications to human beings and their day-to-day lives.

Reversing the Self-Talk

Let's go back to that loud inner gremlin's voice that you're most likely battling on a daily basis.

Think about a runaway train. It takes a lot of energy to keep that train from running down the track. But you can't just throw on the brakes full-stop or just try to hit reverse. The train would veer off the tracks or flip or something very bad would happen.

All you can do is slowly apply the brakes. That's how you bring the train down to a manageable speed so that you can bring it to a stop. Then, finally, you can begin to reverse direction.

So how can we begin this process with our negative self-talk? By beginning to notice.

How often are you listening to the voice telling you that something must be perfect, that you must do better? This will begin to make you aware of how inundated you are.

If it feels like this is happening all day long, it probably is.

Start to notice more about it:

- How is it triggered?
- What does it say?
- What are its favorite catch phrases?
- When does it show up louder than at other moments?

It takes time — like slowing down that runaway train, taming your gremlin is not a process that you can blow through.

If you're interested in this concept, I believe that the book "Taming Your Gremlin: A Surprisingly Simple Method for Getting Out of Your Own Way" by Richard David Carson will be very revealing.

You've got to remember: gremlins are kind of like roaches. When you turn on the lights, they run for cover. They don't want to be seen or identified, their comfort is living in a place where you're not aware of them.

Comparison Is the Thief of Joy

Comparing is only natural. We naturally compare ourselves to both others and previous or imagined future versions of ourselves.

The problem lies in when and how we compare.

We tend to compare the most when we are dissatisfied with our results. When you are not successful, you naturally start looking at others and finding that you measure up short.

For some people, an inability to constantly repeat a past success can move your emotional barometer all over the place.

Stop the insanity!

You've probably heard the adage that "compare equals despair." It's true!

A big part of the problem with comparing ourselves is that these comparisons are skewed. More often than not, they're not actually accurate. They're based on fantasy.

We often have no idea who or what we are comparing ourselves to is actually feeling.

Even if someone appears to be on top of the world — they have a private jet, a family that loves them, they're thin and good-looking, they're the pinnacle of success — what if they have no peace of mind? Day in and day out, they could be completely unhappy.

Things often look great on paper or on Instagram. But that doesn't mean the reality feels good in the course of day-to-day life.

It can be shocking to realize that someone who is a celebrity or “successful” isn’t actually happy. That inside, they have no equanimity, no peace of mind. That they’re deeply depressed or unhappy.

It’s easy to look at someone else and think,

They’re thin, I’m not.

They have a Ferrari, I don’t.

They’re a profitable trader, I’m not.

Look at the bigger picture. You might have a loving partner — they might not. You might have kids who actually talk to you — they might not.

Competition is primal. It’s based on survival. We all have this lizard brain — it’s all about keeping us alive, and it doesn’t like discomfort.

It also informs our competitive streak. If we don’t constantly achieve just a little bit more, we’re potentially at risk. That’s understandable, because for thousands of years, this kind of thinking kept us alive.

But we’re in a different time now. Different parts of our brain have developed. We’ve got an entire limbic system to work with. But many of us haven’t developed this deeper way of thinking and processing. It’s there that we can observe these comparisons going on in the lizard brain and get curious about them. It’s there that we have the ability to step back and say, “I see this comparison going on. What’s up with that?”

Here’s another interesting point ... We rarely compare ourselves to those doing worse than us.

But think about it. If you’re reading this, you could afford to buy a book. Or, you could afford a laptop or e-reader to be reading it on. If you’re a trader, you can afford to put money in your brokerage account.

That’s a lot more than a lot of people in the world have.

For many people in the world, it’s more like “I hope I don’t die of starvation or war.” To not be in that place puts a lot of us at a distinct advantage that we don’t even recognize.

We rarely compare ourselves to suffering people. We compare ourselves to a very small percentage of people who may or may not be actually happy.

With trading, it's possible to make money fast. But to get to that point, you've got to spend a long time — years, even — not making money fast, studying hard, and putting in the work and following the rules.

For some people, the idea of success is actually scary. They might not have a good relationship with money. If you don't have a relationship with money that's healthy and harmonious, it will be a problem no matter what happens.

For some people, there's an ingrained fear of finding success because it could bring on judgment from others. For instance, there's something called "tall poppy syndrome" in Australia, or "crab in the bucket" in other places. The idea is that if you get too big for your britches, you need to be cut down to size.

If you come from a mentality like that, you could sabotage yourself without realizing it because you unconsciously don't want to be ridiculed so you keep yourself small.

We are all driven by a lot of unconscious beliefs. We want to be able to understand what those drivers are so that they don't show up unexpectedly.

Divorce Yourself of Expectations, Free Yourself

Whether you're consciously aware of them or not, you're probably strongly driven by expectations.

What could you do to divorce yourself of them to free yourself?

It goes back to two of the concepts we've discussed previously: getting curious and identifying your needs.

For instance...

How much money do you really need? To have the life I want, to have my needs met? Is it possible that the number in your imagination isn't real?

It's good to be in contact with what your needs are. It can help you begin to divorce yourself from these expectations. It can help you to stop looking at every trade as being part of your personal worth.

Being emotionally attached to a trade is like saying that your worthiness is determined by a trade.

Can you recognize what a risk and weight that is to put on yourself?

Remember: There's so much that you cannot control. It makes your worthiness conditional.

Start by noticing and observing yourself. Get in touch with your tendencies and dependencies.

Noticing what you're doing is really half the battle. It shows you what's costing you and frees you to a different path moving forward.

Did you enjoy this ebook? If so consider the rest of Kim Ann Curtin's ebook series:

Book 1: Ego and Inner Gremlins: How Your Emotions Impact Your Trading

Are you being driven by ego and inner gremlins without even realizing it? For many traders, these monsters of self-sabotage can cause poor decision-making and impulse control. In this book, traders will gain a better understanding of what drives these inner critics so that they can begin to free themselves of destructive inner chatter that may be holding them back.

Book 2 Deconstructing Greed and Fear of Failure

Fear of failure and greed can lead to taking foolish risks and the erosion of both one's trading account and mental capital. That can lead to a toxic cycle of negative self-talk and reduced self-esteem and self-worth. But did you know that fear of failure and greed are usually symptoms of deeper underlying issues? This book helps traders get to the bottom of these issues in a way that can actually bring about positive change in their trading.

Book 3: Navigating FOMO and Comfort With Loss

How often do you trade because you're afraid of missing out? Many traders are driven by FOMO and unsure of how to get comfortable with loss. In this book, traders will get a better understanding of what's behind the FOMO in their lives and trading. In doing so, they can begin to make changes that can improve their outlook, decision-making, and increase their self-mastery.

TheWallStreetCoach.com

(646) 420-2099

info@thewallstreetcoach.com